



Visual Storytelling

Learning the new languages of news

Paul Bradshaw: [MA Data Journalism](#) @ Birmingham City University



1. Why this, now
2. New visual languages: GIFs, emojis, memes
3. Tools and techniques for becoming more visual

Chapter 1:

We are all visual now.

97%
of people focus on **visuals**
on Twitter¹

¹ Source: "Why Twitter" Competitive Research, Kantar Millward Brown, 2017



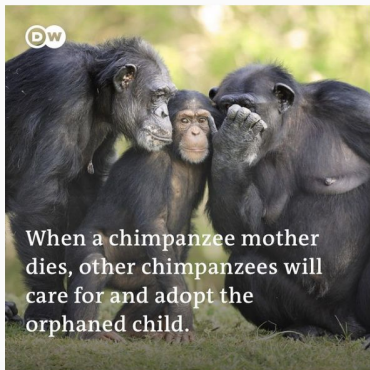
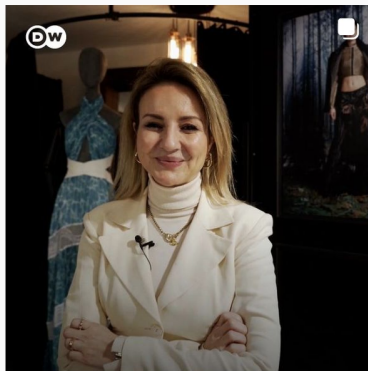
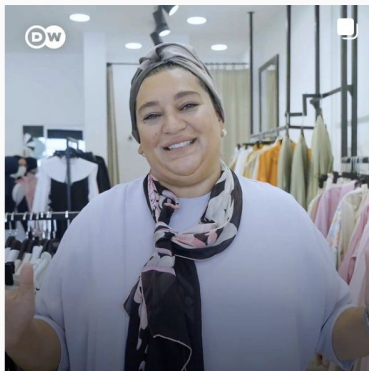
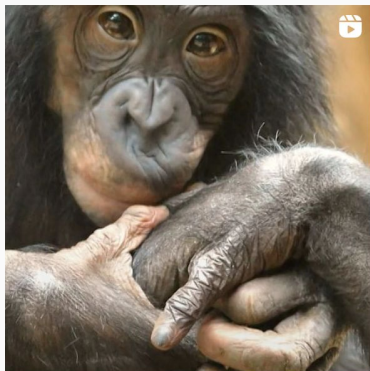
From photojournalism to VisJo*

1. **Photos, diagrams, maps and charts:** old techniques, new contexts (social, square, vertical, carousels, visual platforms, interactive)
2. **Emoji:** one character is worth 100 words
3. **GIFs:** adding movement
4. **Memes:** a familiar story
5. **Text as visuals:** quotes, key facts and numbers

Factual storytelling on Instagram

There are four key characteristics of compelling current affairs images on Instagram:

1. **Emotive faces** – Audiences tend to gravitate towards photos of people that capture strong emotions in situ, as they feel less filtered and more "real" than posed portraits.
2. **Teases the story** – Images that tell part of a story entice audiences to want to find out more.
3. **Provocative/gripping** – Photos that surprise or shock (within reason) stand out and make audiences think.
4. **"Feel good" factor** – Images that convey positivity in the face of adversity fit with the tone of Instagram and can motivate and inspire audiences.



People, places, movement



dwdocumentary

Follow

...

1,547 posts

104k followers

119 following

DW Documentary

Media/News Company

Bite-sized documentary content curated for people on the go. Follow. Discover.

Explore.

Watch our full-length films here

linktr.ee/dwdocumentary

<https://www.instagram.com/natgeodocs/>



natgeodocs



Follow



410 posts

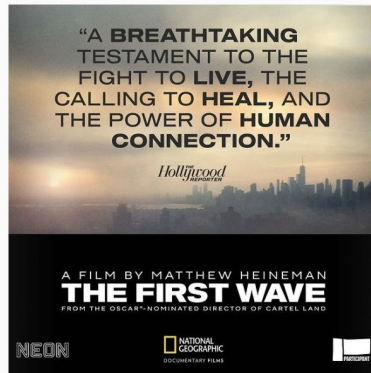
30.6k followers

381 following

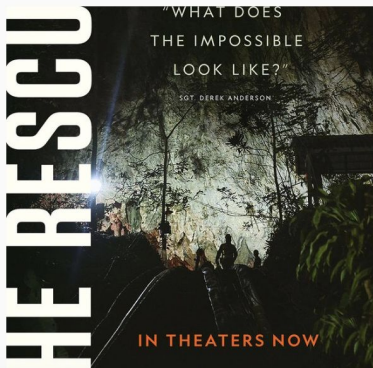
Nat Geo Documentary Films

Official Instagram for National Geographic Documentary Films.

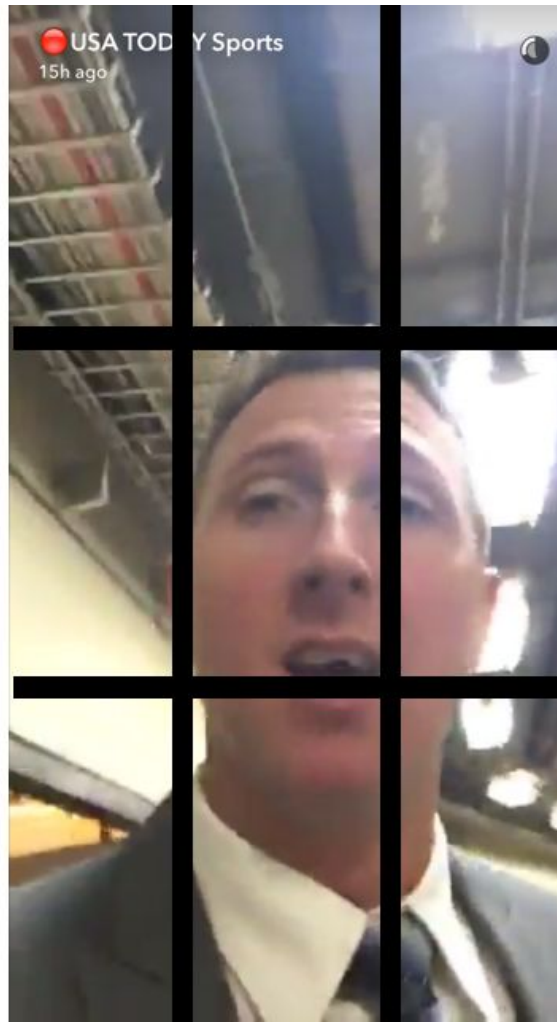
[natgeodocs.com](https://www.natgeodocs.com)



(Not film posters)



<https://www.instagram.com/natgeodocs/>



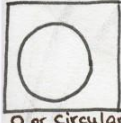
The rule of thirds still applies in vertical



Steeple



Balanced Scales



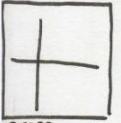
O or circular



S or compound curve



Pyramid or triangle



Cross



Radiating lines



Ell or rectangular



Suspended Steeple



Tree Spots



Group Mass



Diagonal line



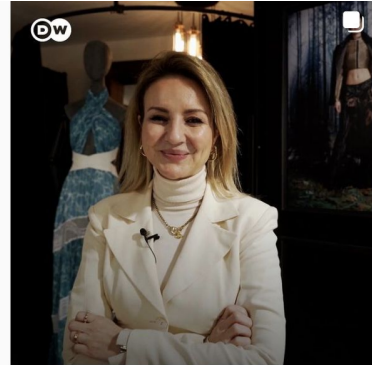
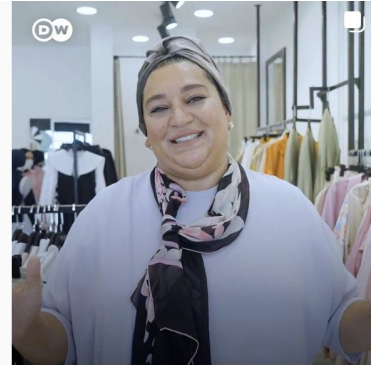
Tunnel



Compositional Guides

From Edgar Alwin Payne's "Composition of outdoor Painting"

Also: increasingly symmetrical



<https://www.muddycolors.com/2021/04/15-types-of-composition/>

Why it's Worth Crying Over Spilled Milk

The climate impact
behind each dairy
and plant-based
pint



The Pudding *etc.*



A quick trip through any dairy aisle
makes it clear we're in a brave new
milk world these days.

Almond, soy, coconut, rice, hemp, oat,
pea... we've left no crop unmilked.



Also: increasingly sequential

But why pick up
plant-based
novelties over
classic cow's milk?



A 2018 Oxford University study suggested
that picking plants over udders could
have huge environmental benefits.

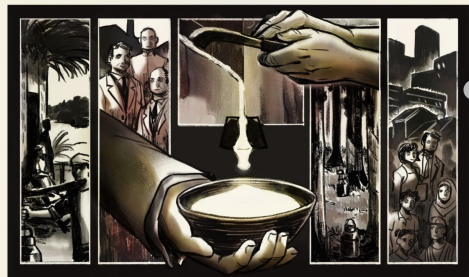


The study is from the UK so all units are metric
(sorry Americans). More info about it in the caption.



<https://www.instagram.com/the.pudding/>
<https://www.instagram.com/p/B5ldkN4hjS6/>

Rubber, Race, and Colonial Exploitation



by Loh Pei Ying and Helena Panicker



Also: increasingly sequential

But lesser known are the racialised dynamics of the rubber trade that discriminated communities, and exploited migrant labour.

Rubber led to an economic boom, but these benefits were not shared. The Europeans enjoyed most of the profits, and set up a highly racialised system of labour and land policy.

Who owned the rubber plantations of Malaya?

General ethnic distribution of share of plantations



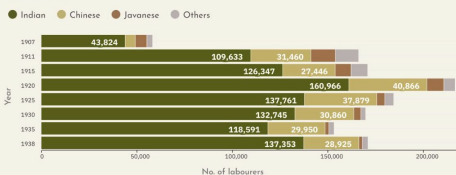
Source: Drabble, John H. 'Introduction'. In *Malayan Rubber: The Interwar Years*, edited by John H. Drabble, 1-8. Studies in the Economies of East and South-East Asia. London: Palgrave Macmillan UK, 1991. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-1-349-18659-7_1, p.2.

Most of the labourers servicing these plantations were Chinese and Indian migrants.

There were different labour practices for the racial groups. The Chinese were hired by a contractor, and worked to pay off their transport debts. Indian labourers, however, had a far worse deal. Until 1912, they worked under an indenture system directly managed by plantation owners. This was akin to slavery, where they were locked in a contract to pay off debts on a fixed and low wage.

Indian labourers were the primary workforce in plantation estates in the early 20th century

Ethnic composition of labour forces in the estates of the Federated Malay States from 1907 to 1938



Source: Anarjit Kaur, 'Indian Labour, Labour Standards, and Workers' Health in Burma and Malaya, 1900-1940', *Modern Asian Studies* 40, no. 2 (May 2006): 425-75. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0026348X06001785>, p. 453

<https://www.instagram.com/kontinentalist/>
<https://www.instagram.com/p/CoEXWJrso2s/>

From photojournalism to VisJo

— — —

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**EVERYONE SHOULD HATE
EMOJI BECAUSE YOU DO?**

FALSE. THAT'S FALSE CONSENSUS EFFECT.

Position	Publisher	Total emoji used	Emoji used	Proportion of alerts containing emoji	Most emoji in a single alert
		206		124/234 (57%)	4
		91		90/91 (99%)	2
		38		24/123 (20%)	2
		32		21/90 (23%)	2
		2		2/78 (3%)	1
		2		2/98 (2%)	1

Based on push alerts received via iOS apps, 26 June - 16 July, 2017



**Guardian US
Mobile
Innovation Lab**

[Tow Center 2017](#)



Stephen Jones ✓

@SteveJonesPA

Following

If you're just waking up, a rough approximation of the parties' local election results so far

Tories 😊

Labour 😞

Lib Dems 😐

Ukip 😖



BBC Wales ✓

@BBCWales

Follow



@luciejones1 emoji factfile



: Lucie Bethan Jones



: 20/03/91



: Pentyrch, Cardiff



: Singer, Actress, Model



: Yup, two



Documentary Network @Documentary · Sep 23, 2020

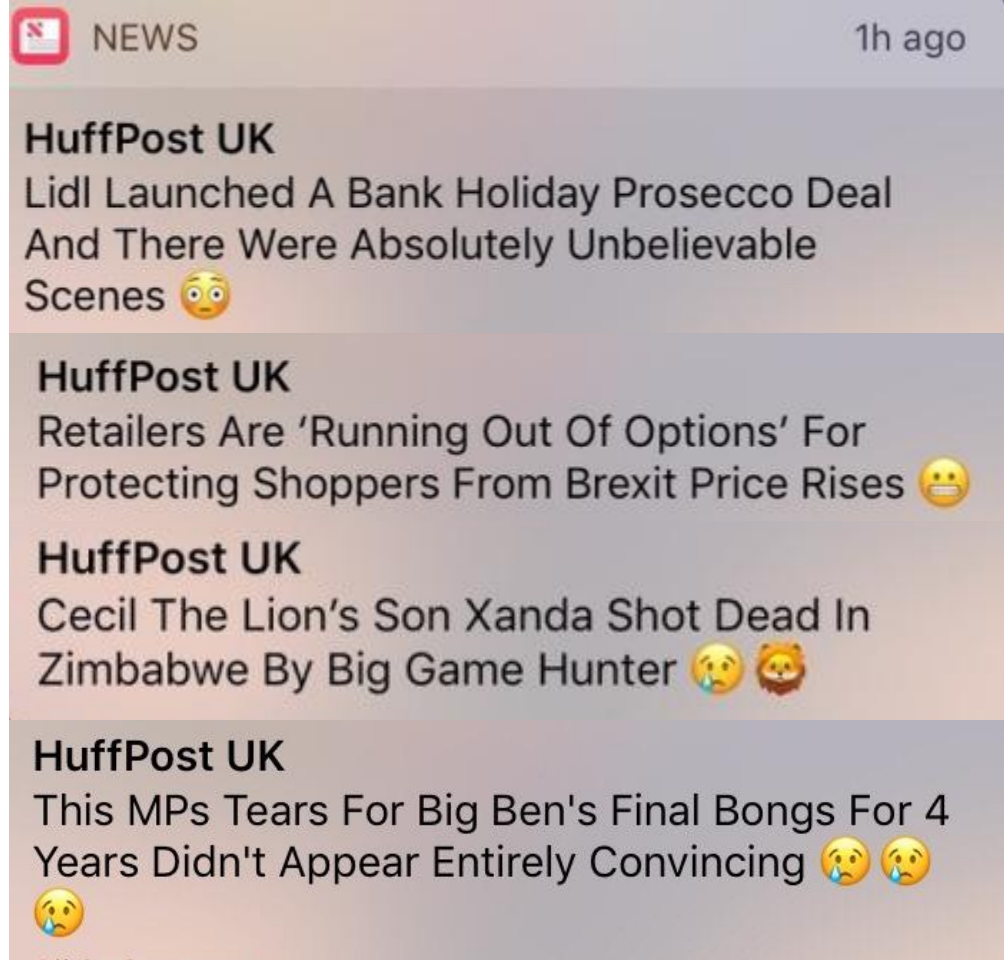
Wave meets cloud 🤖



<https://twitter.com/SteveJonesPA/status/860388147078868992>

<https://twitter.com/bbcwales/status/863490843143016449>

<https://twitter.com/Documentary/status/1308701619912089601>



The different functions of an Emoji:

1. **Show, don't tell:** introducing actors ( ), movement (  ), location ( ). In data,  is often used
2. Setting up **expectations:** this is , , , 
3. **Labelling:** birthday, profession,   
4. **Rating:** good, bad, average, 100
5. **Call to action:**     
6. **Text-as-picture:**   / **Rebus:**

Use sparingly: fewer emoji = more effective. Screen readers use unicode string



Digital Fems 🌂 @DigitalFems · Mar 9

¿Qué es la [#EconomiaFeminista](#)? ¿El Feminismo de datos puede aportar algo?

📌 El 17/03 entre 12-17 tendrá lugar la [#DataFem](#) donde pensaremos acerca de la [#EconomiaFeminista](#) un Indice.

Inscripción abierta y gratis

➡ bit.ly/econfeminista23



The Guardian Nigeria 🇳🇬 @GuardianNigeria · 3h

We didn't remove Igbo, South-south names from election duties - INEC | The **Guardian** Nigeria News - Nigeria and World News ⚠️



Steve Carufel

@stevecarufel_

An economist and a farmer walk into bar, talk about 🇪🇺 ⏮ 🇬🇧

And they just agree on this 🐷 🌱 🐷

bit.ly/2BeJQJR



Ed Conway ✓
@EdConwaySky



Here's a story about how we filled (and continue to fill) the world with a plastic everyone knows is harmful.

- It's a story of the "plastic industrial complex".
- Of the underbelly of the economy
- Of the hidden role table salt(!) still plays in the world.

It's quite 🤔 😞



Ed Conway ✓
@EdConwaySky



📌 THREAD 🗑️

The inconvenient truth about climate change is that solving it will involve digging, blasting & leaching more minerals from the skin of this planet than ever before.

No one much likes to talk abt this.
But talk about it we must.



Ed Conway ✓
@EdConwaySky

🖌️ WATCHING PAINT DRY IS FASCINATING 🖌️

This is a story abt car paint.

🚗 But it's abt more than that.

Its abt the world we live in:

The rise of mass production

The ascent of mass consumption

The rise & fall of economic growth

And why our productivity growth seems to have stalled



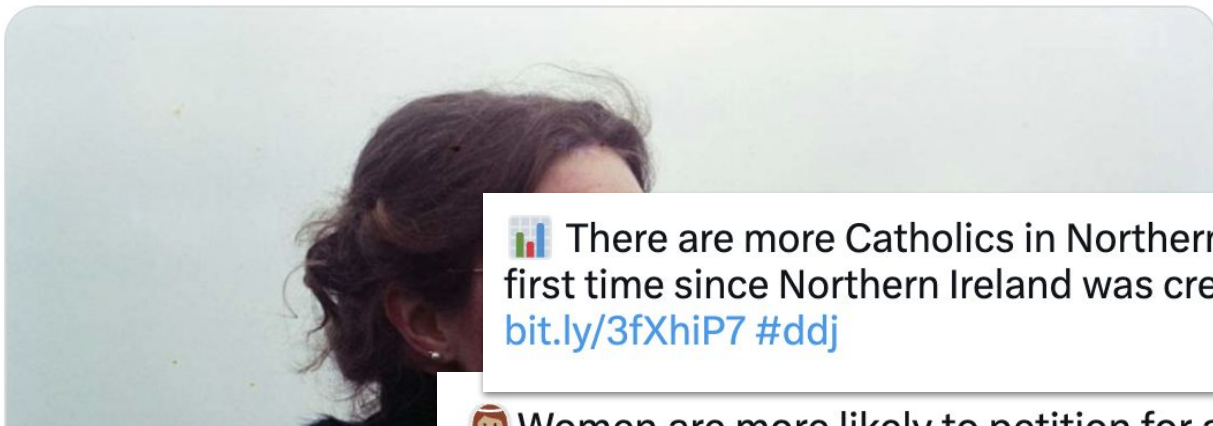


Birmingham Eastside

@bhameastside



🇺🇦 “Something broke inside of me” – Ukrainian refugee reveals why she fled for a new life in the UK bit.ly/3ZyT3ZD



📊 There are more Catholics in Northern Ireland than Protestants for the first time since Northern Ireland was created in 1921, reports @Jarnavic bit.ly/3fXhiP7 #ddj

👩 Women are more likely to petition for a #divorce than men in opposite-sex marriages, according to the latest data from @ONS bit.ly/3NyUwd1 - new story by @jf_amani

🚓 Drink driving offences make up more than 20% of prior convictions disclosed by currently serving West Midlands Police officers, reports @KirstyLCard bit.ly/3R8dCqF



Huw Edwards ✓

@huwbbc



       The BBC's new social media guidance says that the "use of emojis can – accidentally, or deliberately – undercut an otherwise impartial post"

1:21 PM · Oct 29, 2020 · Twitter for iPhone

From photojournalism to VisJo

— — —

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GIFs on social



David Gregory-Kumar ✓

@DrDavidGK

Following



Here's tonight's top VR reactions in GIF form!
More on [@bbcmttd](#) gph.is/2Fgncm8
[@DarkRealitiesVR](#)



[BBC Midlands Today tweet](#); [Reuters](#); [Vox](#)

GIFs in homepages & stories

Thousands of ticketless German football fans fight with police and try to storm into Arsenal's stadium after a day of heavy drinking in central London: Kick-off is delayed and Europa League game could now be CALLED OFF



RAMPAGE AT THE EMIRATES

[Washington Post example](#)
[LA Times example](#);
[Other examples](#)

Hitting opponents when they're down

is to finish off former featherweight champion Jose Aldo, but in down opponent is allowed time to recover in a standing eight-count.



Conor McGregor vs. Dustin Poirier (Winner: McGregor by TKO)

— — —
“Tweets with a GIF gained 55% more engagement than those without”

<https://business.twitter.com/en/blog/6-ways-gifs-twitter-strategy.html>

Case study: Viral Facts Africa

— — —

"[Not using viral techniques] is like bringing a knife to a gunfight. We are trying to use visual, simple and clear messages that are accessible to the public."



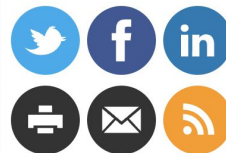
Sub-editing masterclass
Starts 13 March

Home ▾ Jobs ▾ Training ▾ PressGo ▾ PressQ ▾ Freelance ▾ JTweeps ▾ Newsreire

Viral Facts Africa fights covid infodemic with emojis and animated messages

A collaborative project experiments with shareable social content to tackle the spread of coronavirus misinformation on the continent

Posted: 12 May 2021 By: **Marcela Kunova**



Our Newsletter: 

Job Alerts

Sign up to receive job alerts of your choice by email, or manage your subscription

[Kunova 2021](#)

5 ways you can create GIFs

1. **Re-use** existing GIF (e.g. from Giphy)
2. **Adapt** existing GIF (add new text)
3. Create GIF 'clip' **from video** (original or YouTube)
4. Image **sequence** (photos, graphics, charts etc.)
5. **Screen capture** (e.g. scrolling down page/interacting)

Use: in social update, in story, listicle, email newsletter

GIF from library



Birmingham Eastside @bhameastside · Jun 24, 2022

...

Which are the best cities for pet owners to rent a house?

@pupulchatterjee finds out... 🥰👩🏻 bit.ly/3u1BSC6



<https://twitter.com/bhameastside/status/1562109559245885441>

Expectations (show don't tell/mimesis vs. diegesis)



Preview of video

— — —



Birmingham Eastside

@bhameastside

VIDEO: Watch the moment when Birmingham's French community celebrated their [#WorldCup](#) 🏆 win at [@distilleryb16](#) [birminghameastside.com/2018/07/16/wat](#) ... [#bhambc](#)



Created using [freegifmaker.me/youtube-to-gif](#)

Animated sequence of images (as preview)



Birmingham Eastside @bhameastside · Aug 23, 2022

...

🔍 Our data journalist @facostarainis analysed satellite imagery to see what happened when China conducted military exercises near Taiwan - here's what he found 📍 bit.ly/3A1rO4o #ddj



<https://twitter.com/bhameastside/status/1562109559245885441>

Animated sequence of images (as preview)



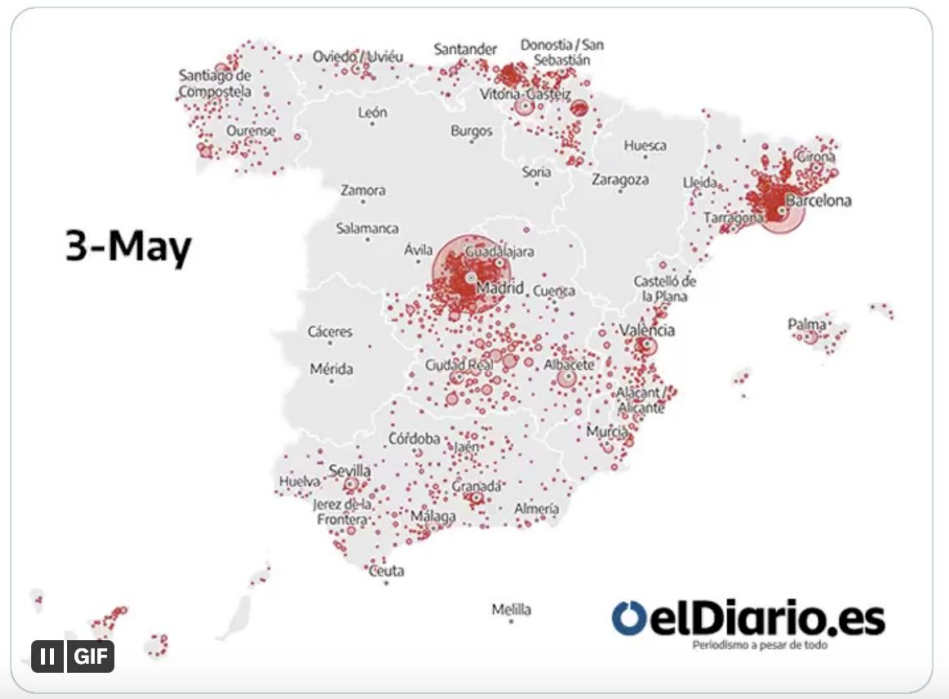
Raúl Sánchez ✓
@raulsanchezglez



2) Mapeamos los fallecidos oficiales en todos los municipios (de más de 500 habitantes) según la base de datos del Ministerio de Sanidad.

Así se expandió el coronavirus en España y cómo ha evolucionado en cada municipio desde entonces 📍

[Translate Tweet](#)



<https://twitter.com/raulsanchezglez/status/136776204194824192>

Screencapture as preview



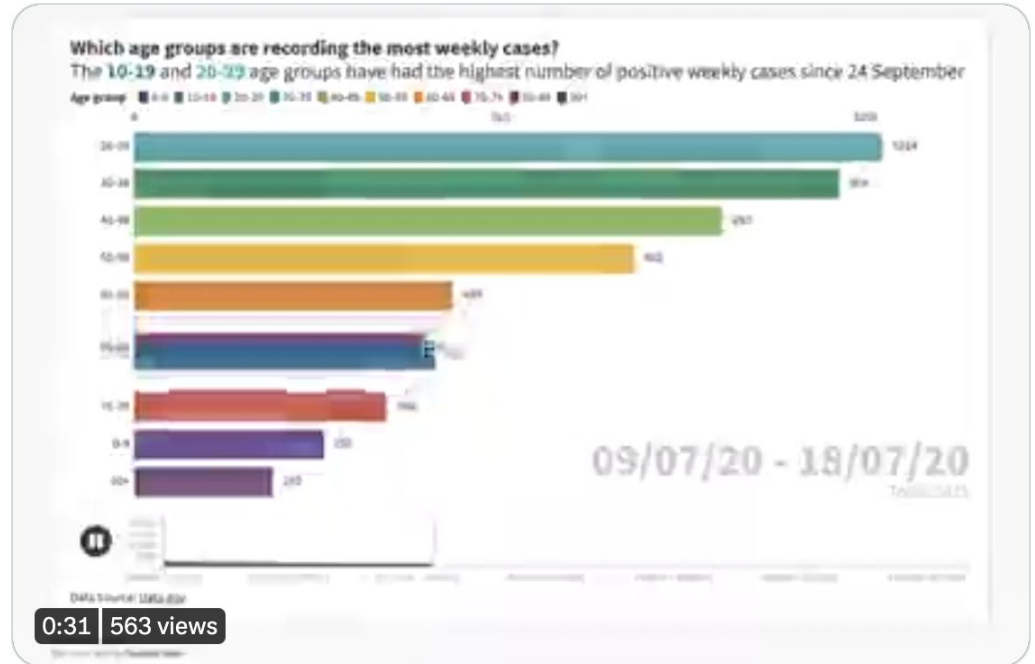
Birmingham Eastside

@bhameastside

...

WATCH: How young people became the leading age group for positive #COVID19 cases 📌

Young people are recording the highest number of weekly Coronavirus cases compared to other age groups.



<https://twitter.com/bhameastside/status/1319271242>

Screencapture as preview



Weiye (Dawn) Cai

@dawncai624



India's Ganges river is one of the most sacred rivers to Hindus, but it's also one of the most polluted in the world. Here we investigate the state of the holy river through data and visuals. --> tmsnrt.rs/2AemoyA
#Ganga



<https://twitter.com/dawncai624/status/1086198284174020609>

Screencapture as preview



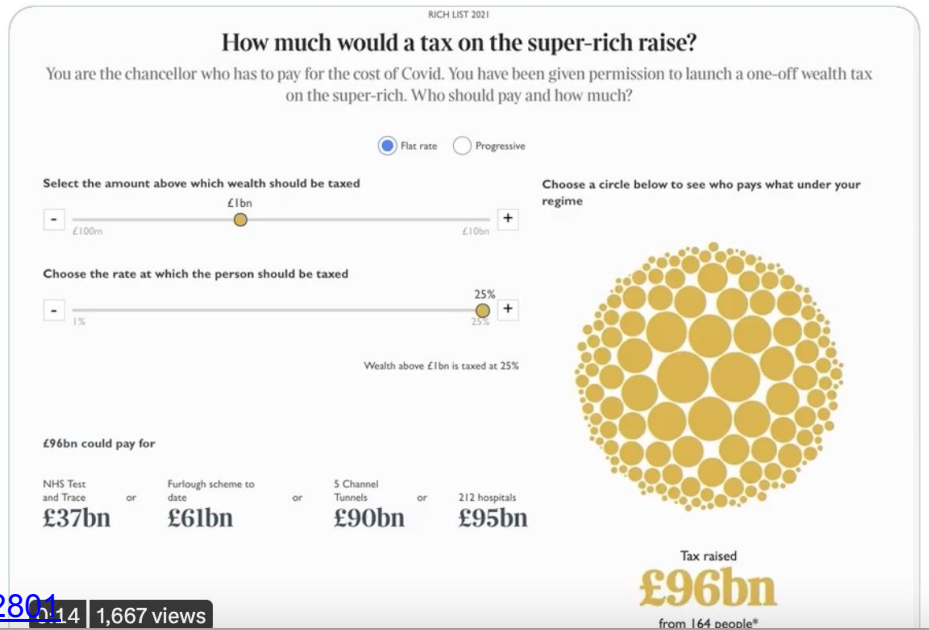
Tom Calver ✓
@tomhcalver

...

NEW: As Britain's billionaires get 21.7% richer, calls grow for a one-off tax on their wealth. What would it look like, how much could it make and who would pay?

Our analysis suggests a 10% "super-rich" tax could pay for the entire furlough scheme 🏛️

[thetimes.co.uk/article/how-we...](https://www.thetimes.co.uk/article/how-we...)

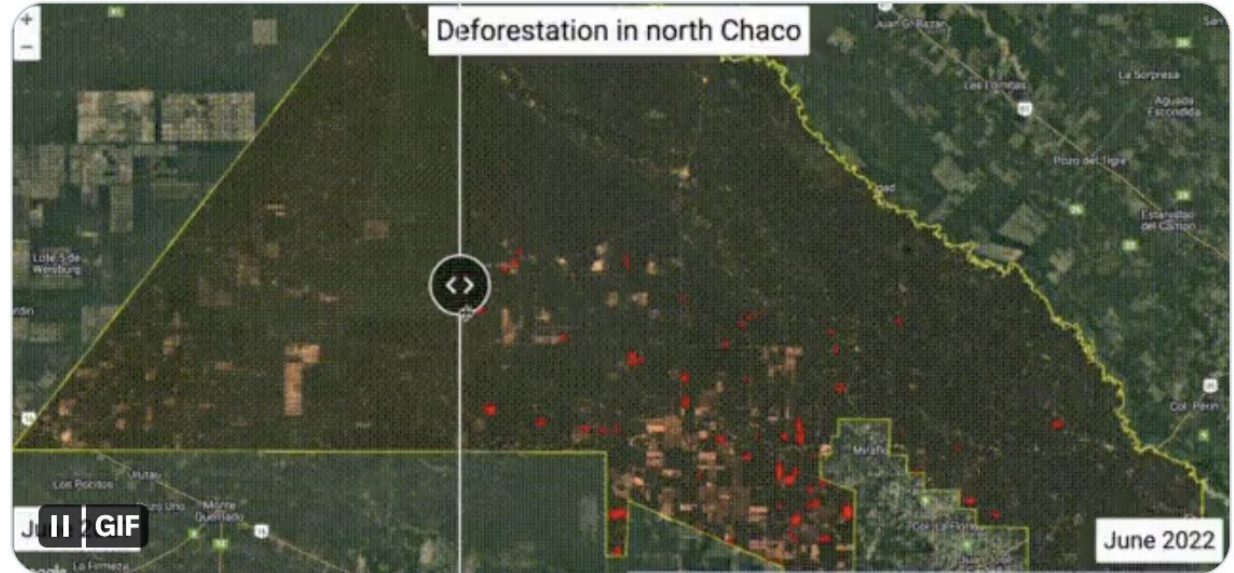


0.14 | 1,667 views

<https://twitter.com/tomhcalver/status/1396154198056652801>

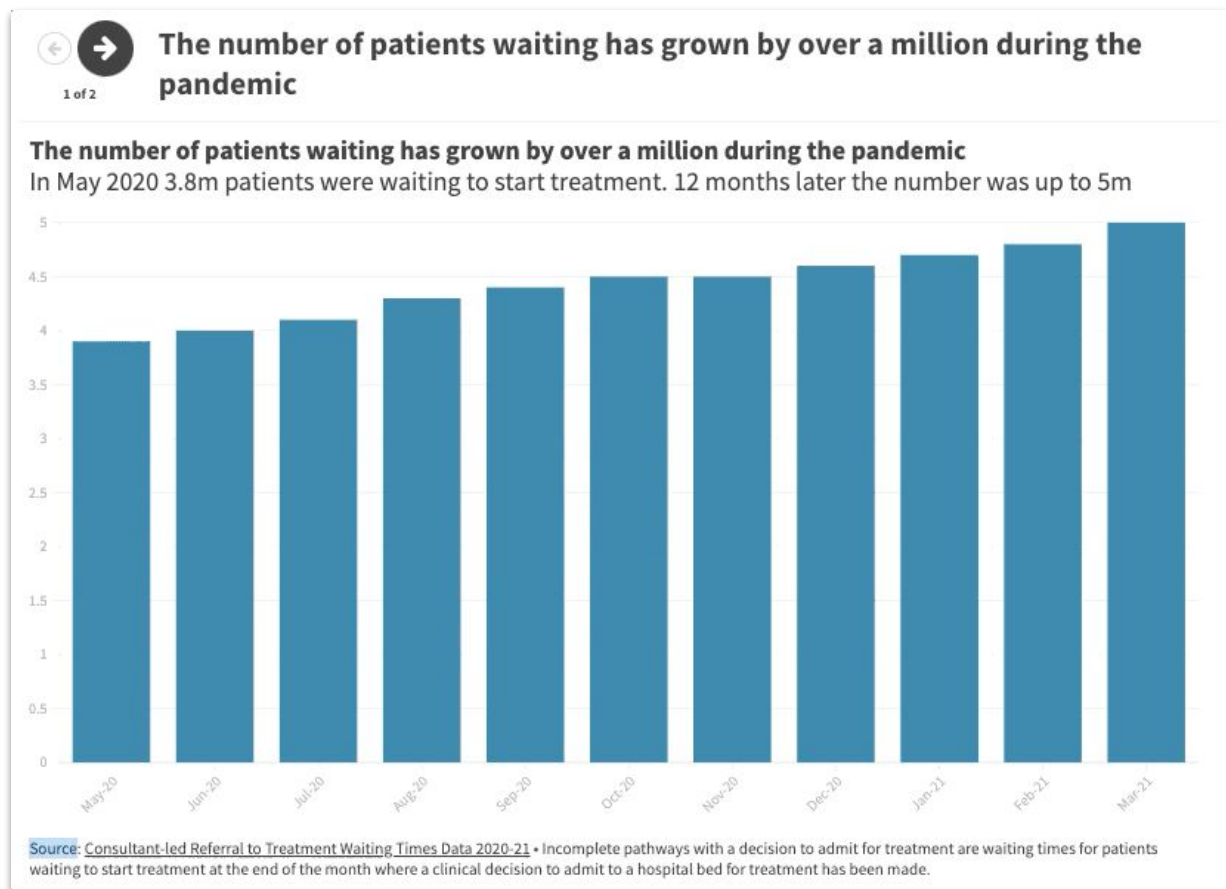
Screenshot as preview

🌳 Special investigation by @facostarainis: Argentina passed a national Forestry Law to halt the destruction of its native forests in 2007 — but 15 years on an analysis of satellite data shows the destruction has still not stopped bit.ly/3TxCB8C



<https://twitter.com/bhameastside/status/1584532199101054979>

Tip: Flourish's story format can be used to animate transitions



<https://public.flourish.studio/story/879164/>

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Internet memes: “a new literacy”

— — —

Meme: “An idea, piece of information, or behavior that is passed from one person to another by imitation” (Observatory on Social Media 2017)

Internet memes: a “particular idea presented as a written text, image, language ‘move,’ or some other unit of cultural ‘stuff’” (Knobel and Lankshear 2007)

WHAT IF I TOLD YOU

**MEMES CAN BE USED
FOR FACTUAL STORYTELLING**



Narrative structure: set up and punchline/twist

Case study: factchecking

“We decided to debunk hoaxes in the same format of the hoaxes that had proven so effective at reaching citizens. We decided to try to make the facts as viral as the lies. And it worked.”



El 'show' de la pacífica abuelita al descubierto: es amiga del terrorista Otegi
okdiano

NO.

NO ES LA MISMA SEÑORA.

HEMOS HABLADO CON LA DE LA FOTO DE LA GUARDIA CIVIL.

SE LLAMA FINA, VIVE EN SANT JULIA DE RAMIS.

NO TIENE UNA HERMANA GEMELA.

LA OTRA ES UNA SEÑORA DE BILBAO.



MALDITO BULO

Case study: pollution in Beijing

“People posted photos, selfies, and GIFs to discuss the impacts of pollution on their lives ... [they] were able to cut and paste images and clips [from a censored documentary], disseminating short bits of video and memes or share the entire video file directly. People started conversations online about pollution.”



Intertextuality



Success Kid / I Hate Sandcastles

Part of a series on Babies. [View Related Entries]

Updated 4 days ago by RandomMan.

Added 8 years ago by Greg McCoral.

Knowyourmeme: [success kid](#)





Mark Di Stefano

@MarkDiStef

It was..... Rebekah Vardy's account.



<https://twitter.com/markdistef/status/1181870274251300864>

Coleen Rooney accuses Rebekah Vardy of leaking stories to Sun

Wife of Wayne Rooney claims fellow footballer's wife passed on her private Instagram posts



Disaster Girl

Updated about a year ago by shevyrolet.

Added 14 years ago by Jamie Dubs.

Knowyourmeme: [disaster girl](#)

“A tiny genre of text in itself”

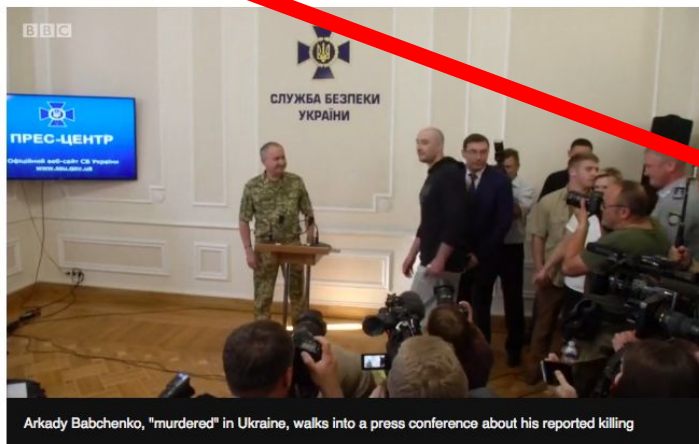
— — —

“Each meme has its own rules and its own grammar ... and is also a kind of game that anyone can join in. And those generally simple rules provide a framework within which each internet meme can be remixed by new participants in new contexts. The rules of each game, each meme, are simple enough to be picked up immediately”

Arkady Babchenko: Ukraine staged fake murder of journalist

15 minutes ago

f t w e Share



Arkady Babchenko, "murdered" in Ukraine, walks into a press conference about his reported killing

Jane Bradley 
@jane__bradley

Follow

This is the first meme I've ever shared but it's a day of firsts so...



4:04 PM - 30 May 2018

482 Retweets 1,609 Likes



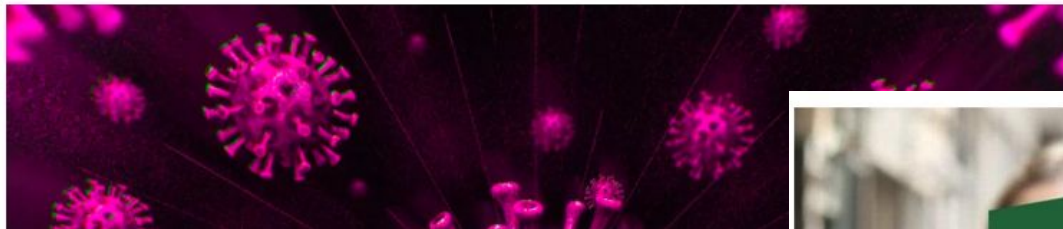
Excel spreadsheet error blamed for UK's 16,000 missing coronavirus cases

The case went missing after the spreadsheet hit its filesize limit

By James Vincent | Oct 5, 2020, 9:41am EDT



SHARE



Putting statues before women, the Tories could end up on the wrong side of history

Nick Thomas-Symonds

The police, crime, sentencing and courts bill could have been a watershed moment. But it doesn't mention the word 'woman'

● Nick Thomas-Symonds is the shadow home secretary





Jon de Plume
@MrJonDePlume



#Clownfall



<https://twitter.com/mrjondeplume/status/1544771621566746627>

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'Judge Me On My Record,' Says David Cameron. So We Did...

The Huffington Post UK | By Andrea Mann

Posted: 05/01/2015 17:27 GMT | Updated: 06/01/2015 02:59 GMT



**“Lessons should
be learned.”**

David Cameron on the Dumfries
floods, **18 December 2009**



ampp3d
from Mirror

**“Everybody needs to
...learn all the lessons.”**

David Cameron on the Somerset
floods, **11 February 2014**



“Lessons should
be learned.”

David Cameron on the Dumfries
floods, 18 Decem



“Everybody needs to
...learn all the lessons.”

David Cameron on the Somerset

Falling oil prices this
year will cost Russia

\$100bn

More than twice the
impact of economic
sanctions so far at

\$40bn

BBC NEWS



Would you pay
\$3m
for 60lbs of
old lion hide?

(Or \$2.9m for
a piano with
Plasticine keys)

BBC NEWS



In eastern Ukraine
13 people
are killed
every day

There have been
957 deaths
since a ceasefire was
called on September 5

BBC NEWS



Pennsv

Sanj
K.



b l a n k o n b l a n k

Famous Names, Lost Interviews

THE PBS SERIES



Wayne Coyne on Living with Death

<http://blankonblank.org/>

Tools and techniques

1. **Canva** to create social graphics from quotes and key facts
2. **Giphy Capture** for screencaptures, or use Quicktime and upload to...
3. **Makeagif.com** for turning YouTube/video clips/pictures into gifs
4. **Gifmaker.me** for turning pictures into gifs
5. **Cheezburger Meme Generator/Imgur/Meme Generator** for creating memes
6. **Flourish bar chart races** and **Flourish stories** for animated charts

Key points:

GIFs, emojis and memes represent a **new visual language** (if you think it's trivial you haven't learnt it yet)

Look for different visual angles (preview, reaction, actors) in your story: **show, don't tell**

Make the non-visual visual: quotes, facts



BIRMINGHAM CITY
University

DATA JOURNALISM - MA / PGCERT

bcu.ac.uk/courses/data-journalism-ma-2023-24

Useful resources



Social Media Graphics

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jaCUQTVZK9o>



[Playlist: composition](#)
See also: [The golden section in composition the work of Henri Cartier-Bresson.](#)



lynda.com

[Narrative portraiture:
course](#)



This visual story needs an angle to liven it up and bring meaning to it. Finding that angle and including the facts means the visual story is far more interesting.



The best way to bring your photos to life is to get your subject doing something. This usually means getting the hands to do something. There is nothing worse than seeing hands hanging by someone's side.



YOU, THE CITIZEN PHOTOGRAPHER

TELLING VISUAL STORIES

BY GIULIO SAGGIN

A CITIZEN JOURNALISM FIRST RELEASE BY
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[Saggin 2016](#)
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https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nC4_kNgsl4c



Rage Comics

Part of a series on Webcomics. [View Related Entries]

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